CHAPTER 4

POLITICS

FOR YEARS, RUMORS rampant throughout the New World told of a mysterious, powerful civilization deep in the jungles of Mexico. The Spanish crown—the most active and well-positioned among its European rivals—began launching expeditions from its stronghold on the island of Cuba: an ideal point of departure for its conquistadors, who had been authorized to trade but not to conquer.

After two failed expeditions led consecutively by Francisco Hernández de Córdoba and Juan de Grijalva, a bolder, brasher, less well-known explorer was selected to lead a third campaign. Some colonial administrators hesitated at this choice, fearing the new captain possessed neither the experience nor the judgment required for the mission, so it was temporarily called off until a more suitable replacement could be found. But hastily, in February 1519, the thirty-four-year-old Hernán Cortés—not to miss his chance at glory—secretly slipped out of Santiago Harbor under the cover of darkness, defiantly setting sail with eleven ships in search of the hidden empire.[1]

From the moment Spanish ships appeared off the Yucatán coast, Aztec scouts were watching closely. But what they observed of these visitors—who sank their own vessels on which they had arrived, rode bizarre-looking deer, and carried sticks of lightning—was initially baffling. Intelligence reports trickled back to their capital, Tenochtitlán, and eventually up to the ninth Aztec emperor, Montezuma II. This time, the supreme ruler of the Aztecs, normally

decisive and resolute, was not.

In Aztec mythology, Topiltzin Quetzalcoatl, Lord of the Toltecs, had brought civilization and progress to the Toltec people, predecessors of the Aztecs. For his leadership and wondrous deeds, the ruler, named after the creation god Quetzalcoatl, was himself widely considered by Aztec descendants to have been endowed with the same supernatural powers.

Let's consider a version of events passed down to us by the Spanish Franciscan friar Bernardino de Sahagún. In that account, Aztec legend held that this man-god, who would later fall from grace, had ventured to the Gulf coast where, drifting off in a small wooden canoe set ablaze, he pledged to return from that same direction across the sea in the then-far-distant year of…1519.

In Sahagún's telling, the landing of Cortés on the date of Topiltzin's predicted return instilled in Montezuma and his closest advisers a mix of dread and awe, reinforced by Cortés's physical likeness to the descriptions of Topiltzin in Mesoamerican myth. But once the credentials of this apparition-like figure were confirmed by successive prognostic signs—a comet, an eclipse, a deformed birth—emissaries promptly arrived from the Aztec capital bearing gifts of gold and a personal invitation for Cortés to meet with the emperor, thus bringing into contact these powerful representatives of the New World and the Old.[2]

The story goes that Montezuma was a generous host—heaping feast and fortune upon his guests and even offering Cortés (as was the custom in Aztec diplomacy) one of his own daughters in marriage. But behind the lavish reception, Montezuma's court and soon his entire empire were sharply divided. His younger brother Cuitláhuac, chief of the fearsome Aztec security forces, had been suspicious from the beginning and pushed aggressively for the foreigners' dismissal.

According to eyewitness accounts, Cortés and his crew, alarmed by the precariousness of their situation but emboldened by their hosts' increasingly public divisions, did the unthinkable: They took Montezuma hostage. Many Aztecs decried the act; others welcomed

it. For nearly a year, the Spanish would rule the Aztecs through Montezuma as their proxy, until hostilities erupted into open conflict. It is unclear why and to what extent the Aztec hosts-turned-captives tolerated this accommodation for so long, but Montezuma's personal acquiescence—voluntary or not—certainly helped to secure the temporary compliance of his vast territory.

Today, no president, prime minister, supreme leader, general secretary, or monarch would be sufficiently prepared for the arrival of outsiders whose timing and advanced technology made them appear godlike. At the time, however, and indeed for long afterward, the case just described was not alone. In the ensuing centuries, statesmen navigating the complexities of colonizations, consolidations, and independences, or addressing the social and political demands of demographically powerful immigrant groups, would frequently fumble even more routine and highly scripted forms of intrusion and transition in leadership.

As AI now arrives on our proverbial shores, it is, like the conquistadors, triggering whispers both of excitement and of mistrust. Some might well be enticed by the potential of this new source of legitimacy to reinforce their rule. Others are scrambling to preclude the potential of an unbreakable dependency, or at least to prepare for the task of navigating its consequences. AI has simultaneously activated an impulse to embrace and to expel.

But will AIs be conquerors? Will human leaders become their proxies: sovereigns without sovereignty? Or, perhaps, will godlike AIs resurrect the once-ubiquitous human invocation of divine right, with AIs themselves as anointers of kings? Alternatively, will AIs be grafted—clumsily, at first, and then more seamlessly—onto our existing structures, to complement and enhance them? Or will AIs be subjugated like an unwelcome migrant class, kept down below their potential and cut off from the levers of power to reassure an apprehensive leadership?

There is no doubt that AI will bestow upon our species a hitherto unimaginable means for advancing the enterprise of scientific discovery, lessening the burdens of labor, and reducing the misery of pain. Far less consensus, however, exists around the necessity or the

desirability of deploying AI in the halls of political decision-making. Even if extraordinary results could be assured in that environment, it is only natural for us to hesitate before ceding such power to technology.

In the realm of science, instruments have generously augmented our sensory apparatus. In the realm of exploration, vessels have shielded our bodies as they deliver us to ever-more-distant frontiers. All along, however, the exercise of political power has rightly remained a humancentric rather than technocentric enterprise.

Until now.

THE WHEEL OF HISTORY

For much of our history, human political power was considered a divine bequest. Faith and politics formed a linked pair. Even after their separation as modern government secularized, they retained certain similarities. As the English philosopher G. K. Chesterton observed, "Wherever the people do not believe in something beyond the world, they will worship the world. But, above all, they will worship the strongest thing in the world."[3]

In that vein, both religion and politics have themselves not only undergone cyclical patterns of creation and destruction but have also anticipated the patterns' recurrence. In Hindu theism, continuous natural and societal evolution occurs through cyclical "nights of chaos" on the endless wheel of existence, with each period—or *yuga* cycle—lasting more than four million years. Many Hindus believe we are currently living in the best part of the worst age, the *Kali Yuga*, an age of spiritual darkness in which humans falsely believe themselves superior to gods.

Analogously, at the individual level in Buddhism, life is a cyclic arrangement of death and reincarnation—an idea recounted in scripture and conveyed in art. With colored sand, Buddhist monks create mandalas—intricate geometric and cosmic diagrams that can take weeks to craft—and then destroy them in minutes, to reflect

the transitory nature of material life.[4] The colossal Buddhist temple on the island of Java at Borobudur and the Hindu-Buddhist temple complex at Angkor in Cambodia are believed by some to be three-dimensional architectural mandalas and are still among the largest religious structures in the world.

The pendulum of political opinion is familiar. It is the mission of enlightened leaders to devote their lives to maneuvers that will withstand internal opposition, outlast external enemies, and shape new patterns of relative peace and stability. Still, even on this extended time horizon, all political leaders act with the knowledge that their work will not remain long after their death and certainly not past the decline of their own state. Just like individual humans, civilizations will at some point disintegrate, as societies become disenchanted with the intellectual maxims and underlying values on which they were built.

What is more, all political and religious traditions recognize the potential for total cataclysm—whether as an end to or a continuation of previous cycles. In the Hebrew Bible, control alternates between God and the sanctioned earthly regent, mandating a restoration of divine oversight each time humanity, spurning the guiding instruction of Heaven, brings itself to the brink of disaster. Buddhists seek enlightenment as an exit and release from further cycles of reincarnation. Hindus believe that our era, the fourth and final *yuga* in the current cycle, will grow increasingly turbulent and anarchic until calamity finally resets the world, ushering in a return to the first age—the golden *Satya Yuga*, during which humanity is governed by gods—and thus the beginning of the next cycle. Praying for redemption, priests and monks of diverse creeds have prepared for the return of a higher being—a child of supernatural ability, an appointed redeemer, the twelfth imam—as either the end or the beginning of history.

In their groundbreaking mathematical studies of change, Isaac Newton and Gottfried Wilhelm Leibniz, contemporaries at odds with each other about much, nevertheless agreed that, under magnification, any curve will appear linear, to the point where an

impending discontinuity will hardly register. The advent of AI into statecraft, that most human field, would represent one such discontinuity, auguring a possibly exponential development of human administrative capacities but simultaneously a radical departure from the traditional world of power and prophecy. The technology makes progress inevitable; politics and faith make destruction and renewal certain. Does AI then represent an exit from our familiar cycles, or merely the start of a much longer one? The beginning of the end, or just the end of the beginning?

TRADITIONAL POLITICS

Human leadership is more art than science. Against sometimes insurmountable odds, some leaders have done exceptionally well. In modern history, conspicuous among such improbably successful leaders have been Deng Xiaoping in China, Alexander Hamilton in the United States, and Lee Kuan Yew in Singapore. All three unleashed latent underlying social forces beyond any one person's control. Deng fused capitalism atop an ancient meritocratic bureaucracy that had no workable economic doctrine; Hamilton allowed a new political philosophy to sweep across a vast frontier in circumstances that had no unified polity; Lee forged an island of excellence by demanding that it arise despite very limited resources.

Each of these three leaders combined astonishing powers of mind with intense force of will and personal charisma. In political language and other forms of persuasive rhetoric, human actors tend to project visions for their societies' futures that—to borrow from Aristotle—are one part *logos* (logic); one part *ethos* (individual authority); and one part *pathos* (emotional connection). These strategies—partly moral, partly psychological—are essential to the creation and sustenance of unified cultural identities and coherent political systems. Leaders are more often than not storytellers, animating audiences and stirring souls.

But our human bias toward the emotional and the aesthetic can

also be our handicap. Even the wisest leaders, propelled by instinct and tempered by caution, sometimes govern on the basis of fleeting passions. Governments (like corporations, churches, and families, all organizations designed and run by fallible humans) are an imperfect combination of inherited tradition and experimentation.

In democracies or autocracies, third world or first, past or present, humans are much the same. The passage of time has yet to yield significant innovation in the way we govern ourselves. We still use the same ancient institutions as did our ancestors thousands of years ago. To be sure, that we still find ourselves reliant upon principles from our distant past is not necessarily a bad thing, and neither should it be a particularly surprising one, as the wisdom of the ancients has often served as the conceptual inspiration and practical foundation for our most successful societies. But those societies themselves might be the exception rather than the rule. For as many times as exceptional figures have adapted historical tradition for the better, an even greater number have tilted history for the worse.

In part, our political consistency may be due to our humanity—alternately loyal and capricious, humble and ambitious, generous and selfish. Our caprice is most evident in systems of autocracy, in which the whims of one ruler can prevail over the consistency displayed by others; the resultant exploitation of national wealth and weaponization of justice are transgressions easy enough to condemn but more difficult to eliminate. Nepotism—which facilitates the aforementioned exploitation and worsens the weaponization—erodes the faith of those spirited citizens who wish to improve the condition of their state and their own situation. Those desperate and brave enough to demand a shift in policy—let alone a change of regime—must be willing to submit to an unfair fight. Instigators of bloody revolutions are often vilified in the short term but—if successful—glorified and mourned in the long.

Unfortunately, democracy too can be vulnerable, if more subtly, to human irrationalities. Despite the absence of formally inherited leadership status, democratic power can be self-perpetuating. The assumption of equality, accompanied by the abstraction of individual

duties to social responsibilities, can override nuance and moderation, resulting in either absolution or total castigation. And, in an age of media saturation, it is difficult to seek the wisdom of democracy beneath the noise. Viral ideas can take on unexpected influence.

Some problems seem to plague any human system. Comprehensively evaluating the path to perfect policy requires a knowledge of innumerable esoteric factors; with limited resources and imprecise social science, results often diverge from original design. In autocracies and democracies alike, politicians—elected or appointed—can make decisions colored in part by the potential for the advancement of their own power or profit. Money drives those who run the world to behave in predictable or, in money's absence, unpredictable ways.[5]

Proper recognition of the mismatch between our expectations and reality has often depended on the ability of acute observers, often from a distance—for instance, Thomas Carlyle (on France), Alexis de Tocqueville (on America), and Oswald Spengler (on the West)—to articulate what to an insider might appear an obvious but unnameable flaw.[6] But we humans are all insiders to our collective global political history. The lack of variety in our historical modes of governance, together with our apparent inability to imagine alternatives commensurate with our civilizational values, has constrained political innovation. AI, as an outsider and disrupter, may open new possibilities, but the cost and benefit of its alternatives are not yet clear.

RETURN OF THE KING

It is perhaps the oldest debate in political philosophy: the struggle either to define or to disprove the viability of one person's wisdom against the wisdom of many. The Greek philosophers Plato and Aristotle put forward some of the earliest competing debates on, among many other subjects, the essence of proper governance. Where the former, speaking in the name of his great predecessor

Socrates, favored a singular "philosopher-king," endowed with seemingly supernatural wisdom and will, the latter found this ideal interesting in theory but impossible in practice, insisting instead that all citizens take an equal share in the administration of the state.

For the next two thousand years, the ideas of Plato, and the reformulations of them that followed, would be repeatedly tested and found wanting on the anvil of application. It was Aristotle's formula that would eventually reign supreme, slowly at first and then quickly in the early modern era as the Dutch Jewish philosopher Baruch Spinoza and other Enlightenment thinkers developed more secular political philosophies. In China, the Ming dynasty statesman, general, and philosopher Wang Yangming coined the phrase "unity of knowledge and action" to describe the two aspects of knowledge that had to influence a ruler's intuition.[7] Leaders were to become at one with philosophy ("knowledge") while simultaneously developing perfect competence across the spectrum of bureaucratic necessities.

In whatever human form the Socratic-Platonic ideal was realized—benign dictator, enlightened despot, a Nietzschean *Übermensch* embodying (in one contemporary interpretation) the "union between the Apollonian and the Dionysian principles and visions of the world"—there were consistent problems with having a singular figure in charge, notwithstanding such a figure's superior intellect, experience, or foresight.[8]

The early medieval Islamic thinker Abu Nasr Muhammad al-Farabi, who would bring Plato's ideas to the Islamic world, also proposed adaptations based on his personal observations of the high court of Persia. Perhaps influenced by his prodigious talent for mathematics, he concluded that any one individual possessing all the necessary virtues sought by Plato would be a gross statistical anomaly; in practice, therefore, the philosopher-kingship must be shared by two persons, "one of whom is a philosopher and the other who fulfills the remaining conditions."[9]

Although al-Farabi would do his best to gather the brightest minds from across the empire in service of the Persian viziers, it was not until six centuries after his death that the Muslim regent Bairam

Khan (1501–1561) would actuate his vision, guiding Akbar the Great and other Mughal emperors under the title of "Vakil": trusted lieutenant and chief mentor to the emperor on all matters.[10] At about the same time, the Italian diplomat and philosopher Niccolò Machiavelli (1469–1527), convinced not by statistical anomalies but by human brutality, would arrive at conclusions akin to al-Farabi's. Exposing the darker side of politics and arguing that power was compatible only with pragmatism, Machiavelli counseled the rulers of Italian city-states to divorce art from practice and suspend ethics in high statecraft.[11]

Four centuries later, the German-American philosopher Leo Strauss would link Machiavelli's ideas with Plato's by concluding that to achieve the ideal model of the philosopher-king, theoretical and political wisdom—that is, philosophers and kings—would have to be kept separate: "There is a necessary conflict between philosophy and politics if the element [contributed by] society necessarily is [only] opinion."[12] Rather than producing a unity of both infused in a single ruler, the philosopher would rule the state through *proximity* to power. In such an arrangement, the philosopher could pursue and apply his or her accumulated knowledge, distant enough from the uncleanliness of politics to preserve purity of thought but close enough for a society to benefit from the result.

The central problem of the philosopher-king was and is, as yet, the limited capacity of a single human mind. Even if enough information could be collected fast enough, the most experienced human leaders would possess only a fraction of the required cognitive function to analyze the information and reach a well-informed decision. The world is just too complex, and human intuition has its limits. Visions of a dual-headed leadership team were only a partial solution to this difficulty.

Humans seldom think of political administration as a capacity to process information. We prefer to elevate in description and stake our political systems to embodiments of values and ideologies. But in both peacetime and war, much of a nation-state's administration is a matter of efficiency in data processing. Failures in information

processing may explain the decline of many overly centralized systems of government, including the Soviet Union. At a certain point during the Cold War, Soviet scientists were planning the creation of a cybernetic political apparatus to equip their Communist political leadership with technological instruments aimed at replacing the free-market forces employed to significant effect by their capitalist rivals.

What Plato wanted two thousand years ago—and Soviet cyberneticists wanted forty years ago—was a complex-systems engineer or, perhaps, an AI. But, prior to AI's invention, a central authority could not make decisions based on local knowledge, at least not efficiently. This insight was articulated most clearly by the twentieth-century economist and political philosopher Friedrich Hayek. Only when we restrained our urge for control did we unleash the invisible forces driving the allocation of talent, wealth, and ideas in ways that had long eluded us.

A key disadvantage for centralized systems when information still had to travel over land and not as waves through the air was the lag time of communication. Some hypothesized that in the twenty-first century, the near-instantaneous speed of information would enable centralized systems to draw even with diffuse ones. That has not yet happened. The bottleneck, it turns out, has not been speed but complexity.

The attributes of machines discussed in this book's prior chapter now make it possible for a centralized AI to compete with and potentially outperform decentralized information processors—its speed reducing even further the latent tension between theory and reality and its scale and resolution ensuring comprehensive scope and precision.[13] Aristotle's democratic answer may indeed have been more ethical than Plato's, but it won the battle of history because it was the more efficient.

This is not to say that AI's information-processing abilities must disrupt democracy itself, but it is a fact that the possibility of efficient centralization is poised to reshape the channels by which democracy is enacted. It might result in the instantiation of a democratic stock

market, a single marketplace of ideas, assessed and valued at incredible speed. AIs may be able to incorporate the perspectives of billions or even trillions of future humans, thereby estimating accurately the current and distant future benefits and harms of—for instance—disruptive technological progress.

Put together, the collective imaginations of these minds could now be amalgamated into a single force, equalizing and potentially expanding beyond the Aristotelian methods. If a single mind could be engineered to represent the collective intelligence and values of a democratic polity—one immense philosopher to stand alongside the (elected) king—then the dual-headed vision of al-Farabi and Strauss could be realized.

Eventually, AI might close the gap between the sciences and the social sciences—political science being chief among the latter. The laws of human nature might become just as predictable, and policy just as reliable, as the laws of physics are to us now.

Unprecedented information processing will enable truly efficient centralization of policy by AIs. One might expect this to reinforce the perception of control by elites. However, the opacity of these systems—and the notion that their operation may be optimized in the absence of human interference—will work in the opposite direction. It is possible that, with time and experience, human control may come to seem less a necessity than a burden. Even as it might initially have felt terrifying for eighteenth-century European leaders to surrender control to the invisible forces of human self-interest, the political leaders of the twenty-first century may yet be required once more to humble themselves before a system that incorporates the wisdom of the masses in an entirely new form.

RULE BY REASON

If and when AI begins not only to process information for political purposes but also to make political decisions, new questions will pose an unfamiliar challenge to conventional political wisdom.

Political science does not even provide guiding terms for such a shift. How might an onlooker assess the "superiority" of a strategic decision made by an AI, in the absence of interpretation of the logic by which the AI made the decision? The outcome, of course, would be one metric. But something significant would be lost, not least for historians, in the absence of a record setting out the principles of action.

In many future cases, humans might disagree with the plans produced by AI not because they are unwise but because the rationale for an AI's decision is beyond the scope of immediate human comprehension. It might be especially natural to wish to prevent or delay an outcome in which humans lose not only temporal control over machines' decision-making processes (the ability to intervene) but also logical comprehension of those processes (the ability to interpret), even after the fact.

In situations in which human and AI leadership diverge and disagree on matters of statecraft, which party's judgment should win out? Does the answer change if it becomes apparent that AI guidance, more than human counsel, effectively contemplates human end-states far in the future—and thus would be, in the long term, more beneficial than human discernment?

The utilitarian part of human intuition would be inclined to accept a farsighted AI's judgment, especially if the AI could explain the justification for its decisions. But, even then, situations may arise in which humans would protest a policy that, although ensuring the longevity of our species and of those persons not yet born, would be harmful to living humans here and now. Similarly, AIs might welcome rational outcomes, like settlements of military conflicts, that would be politically unacceptable to all parties to the conflict. The chances of outright rebellion would be high. Even if the concept of governance by machine were accepted, and even if that machine's logic were explicated, and even if that machine's decisions were rational, beneficial, and superior by some measures, we still might prove ungovernable. Among humans, only politics that incorporate an element of the intangible can be sustained. As Tolstoy writes, "If we admit that human life can be ruled by reason, the possibility of

life itself is destroyed."[14]

Those nonrational elements of the human experience—history, above all, but also aesthetics, charisma, and emotional resonance—may hinder optimal outcomes, in some sense, but they are also foundational to our political groups. Rule by reason alone could dissolve nations. Overly rational AIs and their human partners could quickly lose control over or cause the disintegration of the structures of power in which they cooperate.

Then again, AI might be most valuable and most needed precisely where its logic appears strange, counterintuitive, or just outright wrong. While AIs may be used to accelerate the resolution of problems toward known solutions—expanding human options by achieving a speed that avoids the political costs of delay—perhaps the even greater use of AI would be to think through what we cannot and land on entirely novel solutions. Indeed, this may be one of the key purposes of its creation.

But this attitude also carries risk, in proportion with its openness to opportunity. It leaves humans no basis on which to correct or ignore the potentially unacceptable and previously unimaginable decisions of an uninterpretable AI. The impulse not to hinder AI would only grow, exacerbated by the potentially evident superiority of AI governance as compared to past human governance.[15] An AI governor might deliver truly unbeatable results. If it did, stopping its use or circumscribing its scope would seem illogical—particularly in the context of geopolitical competition, in which refraining from use would seem to guarantee disadvantage.

Likewise, human leaders who become so accustomed to superior outcomes provided via AI would habitually depend on it for their own legitimacy. AIs might also develop their own biases: If a human leader loyal to an AI partner wished to overstay his or her term of appointment, would an AI intervene to halt such a violation of protocol?

PROMETHEUS

Throughout history, leaders who claimed to know what was best for their people, better than the people knew themselves, were soon disproved by reality.[16] Friedrich Hayek warned that central planning or similar forms of governance—including those forms not yet conceptualized during his time—would by definition forbid the expression of dissent.[17] Without, or even with, accurate information, planning can become a strong argument for prioritizing the collective over the individual—a pursuit of utilitarianism without obstruction. That is not inherently bad; but beyond a certain point, such a government can reach escape velocity, exiting the realm of normal governance and becoming eternal in ubiquity—with its subjects forced to be free, coerced for our own good. An AI-fueled administration could, in the words of one neuropsychologist, "claim to know what its people truly want and what will really make them happy… at best [used] to justify paternalism, at worst, totalitarianism."[18]

So long as we have known ourselves better than our king has known us, liberalism has been a restraining force. Now, as some have suggested, AI will "tell us who we are before we [know] ourselves," giving totalitarians not just an operational tool but a "philosophical weapon."[19] AIs could thus undermine the tenets of Immanuel Kant:

> No one has a right to compel me to be happy in the peculiar way in which he may think of the well-being of other men; but everyone is entitled to seek his own happiness in the way that seems to him best, if it does not infringe the liberty of others in striving after a similar end for themselves when their Liberty is capable of consisting with the Right of Liberty in all others according to possible universal laws.[20]

In the technical process of building AI, machines are taught that errors are wrong. That is purely useful insofar as it corrects humans' mistaken assumptions and suboptimal implementations. But another

cause of error in our human systems is our individual free will—we are free to make the "wrong" choice. If an AI system decides to remove such errors, it faces two options: Remove us, or remove our free will. If free will is, by default, to be considered not a feature of intelligence but a bug, it may also be increasingly seen as a barrier preventing AI from accomplishing its own goals.

Humans have grown accustomed to both appreciating and despising the fact that the sheer strength of human will is what drives our world. History has been written in such a way as to show humans as the principal authors of our story; in that story, individual leaders have exercised the authority to see that empires rise and fall on their command or that great conquerors can exert enough stability to tame chaos. Total uncontrol may be rejected, even if it were known to maximize AI's ability to act in our (and future generations') interest.

The balance between control and uncontrol may be influenced by the problem of time discussed in the previous chapter, with humanity's and AI's perceptions operating on distinct timescales. AI is unlikely to be distressed by the speed at which it acts; it will view as natural the rate of change it creates. By contrast, the benefits to accrue from AI could be so dramatic—and, to humans, so unnaturally fast—that, sometime soon, our species may feel that we have drunk of it as much as we can tolerate and that any more would be more disorienting than pleasurable and therefore not worth the cost.

That does not necessarily spell the end of change. It simply means that, in order to bring along societies intact, the benefits that may be reaped from AI would need to be incorporated into human institutions incrementally, or at least more slowly than maximizers of distant future goods might like.

Many will be familiar, for example, with the story of Prometheus, the titan who stole fire from the gods to give to humans.[21] Fewer know that, in doing so, he was fully aware in advance of the cruel punishment he would receive from Zeus: namely, being chained to a rock for all eternity with an eagle eating his liver (which regenerated

overnight) each day. What remains unanswered in the myth, however, is why Prometheus would choose to sacrifice himself, knowing in advance, as he also did, all the horrors that humanity would unleash with his gift. Perhaps he chose as he did, and is called a hero rather than a villain, because humanity would unleash very good things as well.

Cabined to partnership with humans, rather than unleashed toward domination of them, AI may help humans govern in obscure ways that are reminiscent and reflective of a similar kind of inaccessible forethought—"forethought" being the very meaning of the name *Prometheus* in Greek. But it may be accepted as a hero only if it exercises that forethought in service of humanity, a humanity that retains real individual agency and political coherence, even by way of some irrationality.

A NEW ACT

Examining the historical record, we might find most notable not the amount of change to be seen in politics but rather the remarkable absence of change. The same archetypes of leadership exist today as have existed for thousands of years: the tragic hero-prince, the treasonous adviser, the honorable lieutenant, the court jester, the shadowy puppet master, the unreliable mercenary. If politics is theater, these familiar characters help us explain the otherwise inexplicable and animate the otherwise arcane.

Long before Catherine was great, Yaroslav wise, Ivan terrible, or Suleiman magnificent, they were not. And we admire these leaders in part because history has borne witness to their personal evolutions. We look with special awe upon those born in debilitating circumstances who through sheer conviction have escaped the shackles of adversity to rise to the top of their society. The Mamluk king Iltutmish, sold into slavery by his own brothers out of jealousy for his good looks and sharp intelligence, would serve Uzbek and Afghan slave traders in Bukhara and Ghazni before eventually being

purchased by a Ghurid slave commander at a market in Delhi. Only two decades later, he, the slave of a slave, would rise through the ranks of the sultan's service, founding a "slave dynasty" atop the kingdom of his former masters.

Of course, the fall from power can be just as unexpected as the rise. No leader can guarantee immunity against being toppled by revolution or hanged by conspiracy. Whether by suicide like Nero, duel like Hamilton, or assassination like Gandhi, greatness cannot escape the graveyard.

As leaders in history, such figures hold a common stake in basic order and security. But as brothers and sisters in the family of man, they, like all of us, are not without jealousy, mutual suspicion, and sibling rivalry.[22] The same struggles are found in our own households as in ruling houses, in generations of common folk as in dynasties of royal reign. We can sympathize with the difficulty of overcoming jealousy and forging alliances with former enemies—as was done by Dowager Cixi, a former concubine who would come to rule China—just as we can despise the treason of General Mir Jafar, whose defection at the Battle of Plassey effectively handed control of India to the conquering British in return for the perfunctory title of "first Nawab of Bengal." If rulers were too godlike, too perfect, or too competent, they would not experience anxiety, despair, love, or envy. The familiar emotions and vulnerabilities encountered by all humans also turn the wheel of history.

Human politics is both commendable and condemnable because of its spiritual proximity to our own personal politics. Though Napoleon could tame Europe, he could not tame the heart of Joséphine; the rivalry between John Adams and Thomas Jefferson feels as familiar as our own brotherly squabbles; Tolstoy's *War and Peace* is no less about the principal events of history than about the individual lives that inhabit those events.[23] The men who in the fifteenth century CE would follow nineteen-year-old Joan of Arc to war were not so different from the men who in 324 BCE mutinied against Alexander the Great at Opis after he had conquered most of the known world. Alternating between the political and the personal,

the real merges with fiction, historical chronicles with epic poems.

A mechanical politics would lack such narrative tension. Without the purging of rivals or the rapprochement with old enemies, the sudden rise to power or the rapid fall from grace, statecraft might become less relatable, less entertaining, even boring. With no more distinction between tragedy and comedy, the imperial court would become void of drama and intrigue.

Alternatively, the emergence of AI as a novel character could represent the inciting incident of a new act in human politics. It could change the natures of, and the dynamics among, the familiar human archetypes. But some things would not change; the finite lifespan of the human guarantees our narrative arcs, our rises, our falls. Our evolved social nature dictates our loves, ambitions, and moralities.

It is this same imperfect feature of our politics that we should aim to preserve and subsequently combine with the perfection of AI systems in becoming complementary partners. AI, lacking the inconsistencies of the human soul, will be unconstrained; for better and for worse, our flightiness has acted as a stifling cap on our potential but also as a reliable restraint on the extent of our evil.

Human rule today relies on our long experience with historical contingency. AI's value in governance, so far dormant, lies in its potentially perfect knowledge. Today's human leaders should prepare to be the first in a line of human sovereigns to face the struggle of locating a balance between leveraging the advantages—and, in some cases, the need—for AI in governance without going so far as to succumb to total dependency, instead finding the proper synthesis between the extremes of despotism and anarchy, merging the will of humans, the knowledge of machines, and the wisdom of history.